Bobcats blank Berea

By Caleb James

For The Journal

BEREA — The Seneca High School football team wasted no time setting the tone Friday night, rolling to a 49-0 win over Berea to move to 7-1 overall and 3-1 in Region play.

Thoma came out sharp, directing five touchdown drives on Seneca's first six possessions and finishing with 276 yards and five touchdown passes, all before halftime. In doing so, he quietly set a new school record for single-season touchdown passes, a milestone that illuminates what has already been a standout senior campaign.

"I felt like we handled our business early, like we needed to," head coach David Crane said after the game. "That was great to give us a chance to get some other guys in there to play, which was really fun to see."

From the opening kick, Seneca's offense was crisp and efficient. Thoma hit Coltyn Hawk on a 14-yard strike to open the scoring, then found Elias McGee deep down the sideline for a 46-yard touchdown. Moments later, he dropped a perfect pass to Cole Kanagy for a 31-yard score that made it 20–0 by the end of the first quarter.

In the second, Seneca's rhythm continued. Thoma connected with Jack Webb on a 14-yard touchdown and Elias McGee on a 35-yard catch-and-run that showcased the Bobcats' speed and spacing. McGee finished with three receptions for 136 yards, while Webb, Hawk, and Kanagy each found the end zone once.

"Just trusting my players, getting them the ball, and they made plays after the catch," Thoma said. "It starts with preparation on Monday and being locked in all week."

While the offense drew headlines, the Bobcat defense was equally dominant. Seneca's front seven controlled the line of scrimmage and prevented Berea from finding any rhythm.

"Elijah's just so fast with the ball in his hands, and Gavin made some really good throws," Crane said. "But I thought our defense set the tone, too. They played with focus and energy all night. That kind of complete effort is what we've been looking for."

As the game wore on, the Bobcats' depth became the story. Junior Jamari Sprout punched in a short touchdown run in the third quarter, and later, backup quarterback Eli Wylie found Tristan Walker on an 11-yard touchdown pass to cap the scoring.

With the shutout win, Seneca now turns its attention to next week's pivotal region matchup against Greer, a game Crane expects to test his group's maturity.

“Greer’s always got a great football team,” Crane said. “That’ll be a big challenge for us. We need to hit the reset button Monday and get back to work.”

Seneca 49, Berea 0

SHS 20 17 6 6 — 49

BHS 0 0 0 0 — 0

SCORING SUMMARY

First Quarter

SHS — Hawk 14 pass from Thoma (kick failed), 9:45

SHS — McGee 46 pass from Thoma (Simmons kick), 6:21

SHS — Kanagy 31 pass from Thoma (Simmons kick), 3:24

Second Quarter

SHS — Webb 14 pass from Thoma (Simmons kick), 10:43

SHS — McGee 35 pass from Thoma (Simmons kick), 7:32

SHS — Field Goal 25 good (Simmons kick), 0:04

Third Quarter

SHS — Sprout 3 run (kick failed), 9:03

Fourth Quarter

SHS — Walker 11 pass from Wylie (kick failed), 4:43

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TEAM STATISTICS

SHS BHS

First Downs 17 - 0

Total Yards 435 199

Rushes-Yards 20-99 18-188

Fumbles-Lost 1-0 0-0

Com-Att-Int 10-18-0 3-11-1

Passing Yards 336 11

Pen-Yards 3-20 4-35

Punts-Avg. 7-40.29 0-0

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INDIVIDUAL STATISTICS

RUSHING — Seneca, Verner 8-49, Sprout 7-39, Lee 4-6, Jones 1-5, Berea, Scates 4-74, Leamon 3-70, Gary 3-3, Lee 3-7, Shoemaker 1-3, Bradley 3-1, Mayer 1-0

PASSING — Seneca, Thoma 7-10-0 276, Bene 2-6-0 24, Wylie 1-2-0 36; Berea, 3-11-199
RECEIVING — Seneca, McGee 3-136, Webb 3-59, Verner 1-36, Kanagy 1-31, Holden 3-28, Walker 2-24, Hawk 1-14, Shoemaker 1-8; Berea, Bryant 1-6, Bradley 2-7, Gary 1-1.